

“The introduction of so powerful an agent as steam will make a great change in the situation of man,” predicted US President Thomas Jefferson (1801–09) in a letter in 1802. Two years later in 1804, on a different continent in South Wales, Britain, a steam locomotive trundled across about 16 km hauling wagons packed with iron and 70 men. Mechanical engineer and inventor Richard Trevithick’s invention, the locomotive, though slow, impractical, and clumsy, marked the beginning of the steam age, changing the world, and revolutionizing the concept of distance and speed. Today, there is barely any region in the world that has not witnessed the magic and romance of the railways, as it has evolved from a mere vehicle of transportation into a symbol of modernity and progress. For the traveller, it is much more than an iron horse; it provides an invaluable space where communities meet and stories unfold.

Dawn of steam locomotion

Trevithick did not give up on his machine. By 1808, he created *Catch-Me-Who-Can*, another steam locomotive, which pulled people around a circular track in London. Brittle rails unable to bear the weight of his machines, however, meant that he discarded the project, moving on to other things.